

Ancient Power
By Matt Cook

They come from all over to the city of Boston, disembarking at private terminals and into chauffeured limousines. Flight numbers are misremembered, passenger manifests inconsistent. At Harvard Square station they step gingerly off downtown trains past the “DO NOT CROSS” sign at the end of the platform, walking over both sets of tracks, trains delayed by their conductors on cue, though nothing is officially reported. Distracted fellow riders don’t notice or take the travelers to be masked partygoers, a curious but ultimately forgettable sight.

The supplicants stoop and enter a decrepit passageway a short way down the tracks, which leads them under the Yard, and into the basement of the undergraduate library. They turn common corners and traverse fluorescent hallways and are soon beneath the famous Widener Library at the heart of campus. To each other, they nod, but otherwise no one speaks. And no one is allowed in the building that night except the grey-uniformed door guards, and only those few who have been trained to stay near their posts. All their managers report in turn to one manager, who once a year sees a man about-a-thing. A bonus will arrive on the 1st for those who play ball. Nothing is ever questioned.

To sub-basement three where a locked storage cage holds surplus office supplies. It’s a deliberately mundane scene – staged - though a game trail weaves between the mishmash of strewn furniture and stacked bookends. Their movement becomes epileptic as they pass through a stone portal hidden beneath a faded painter’s tarp and enter a smog filled room deep beneath the Earth. In that dark place the shape of the smoke from a crack in the flagstone foundation

condenses and solidifies before their eyes, filling in the visual field like living entities with pulsing, bulbous flesh. Grotesque apparitions whisper to them what to do next. How to vote. Chattering voices in your ear you should not imagine and cannot ignore.

These titans of industry, consigliere, campaign managers, and special counsels are not the first to breath in that foul smoke. Before pilgrim ministers planned their sermons there, *Massachusetts* holy men meditated on the harvest there while catamounts would sometimes den there with their cubs in a storm beneath the rock, emerging with uncharacteristic bloodlust, having devoured their offspring without mercy. Before that...who knows. What's clear is what comes after. Without question. Without invitation. Without God, they return each year. This is the true source of their worldly power and they would be foolish to abandon it.

